JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category 4: Health & Emergency Awareness

Module 6 – Mental Health & Emotional Well-being

Module Overview

Mental health shapes how we think, feel, work, and connect with others — yet it remains one of the least discussed parts of everyday health in India. This handbook is Module 6 of JanGyan's Health & Emergency Awareness category, and it gives every citizen — students, working professionals, parents, and senior citizens — a clear, practical understanding of mental well-being.

By the end of this handbook, you will understand what mental health really means, how to manage stress and anxiety, recognise the signs of depression, protect your sleep and digital well-being, and know exactly where to turn for professional support in India. This module is designed as a complete, self-sufficient guide.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Explain what mental health means, beyond the absence of mental illness.
- Apply practical techniques to manage everyday stress.
- Recognise the general signs of anxiety and depression.
- Build healthier work-life boundaries and digital habits.
- Practise simple sleep hygiene and relaxation techniques.
- Know where and how to seek professional mental health support in India.
- Separate common mental health myths from accurate facts.

Why This Topic Matters

Important

India's National Mental Health Survey found that nearly 150 million Indians need mental health care, yet fewer than 30 million are receiving it — an overall treatment gap of about 84.5%. For common conditions like depression and anxiety, that gap runs even higher.

Much of this gap isn't about a lack of care — it's about a lack of awareness. Many people don't recognise the signs in themselves or loved ones, don't know that free, confidential government support exists, or hesitate because of stigma. Mental health struggles are common, human, and in most cases, genuinely treatable.

This handbook exists to close that awareness gap — one honest conversation at a time.

Introduction

For a long time, "health" was thought of purely in physical terms. That view has changed — the World Health Organization now defines health as complete physical, **mental**, and social well-being, not merely the absence of disease.

Definition

Mental Health is a state of well-being in which a person can cope with the normal stresses of life, work productively, and contribute meaningfully to their community.

Mental health is not a fixed label — it exists on a spectrum, moving between thriving, coping, struggling, and being unwell, depending on what's happening in someone's life. Everyone moves along this spectrum at different times; the goal is not to "never struggle," but to build the awareness and support to move back toward well-being when you do.

Remember

Needing support for your mental health is no different from needing support for a physical illness — it is common, human, and nothing to be ashamed of.

Fundamental Concepts

1. What Is Mental Health?

Mental health covers our emotional, psychological, and social well-being. It affects how we handle stress, relate to others, and make decisions — at every age, from childhood through old age.

Dimension	What It Includes
Emotional	Recognising and managing your feelings
Psychological	How you think, learn, and make decisions
Social	The quality of your relationships and sense of belonging

2. The Mental Health Spectrum

Rather than a simple "healthy vs unwell" divide, mental health is best understood as a continuum:

Stage	What It Looks Like
Thriving	Coping well, generally positive mood, strong relationships
Coping	Managing, but under some visible strain
Struggling	Persistent difficulty coping, noticeable impact on daily life
Unwell	Significant impact on functioning, professional support strongly recommended

Tip

Most people move between these stages many times over a lifetime. Checking in with yourself honestly is the first step to noticing when you need extra support.

Complete Detailed Explanation

Each topic below covers what it means, why it matters, and practical steps you can use straightaway.

3. Stress Management

Stress is the body's natural response to demand or pressure. In small doses, it can sharpen focus ("eustress"); in excess or over long periods, it becomes harmful ("distress").

- **Common triggers:** Work deadlines, exams, financial pressure, family responsibilities.
- **Healthy coping tools:** Deep breathing, regular physical activity, talking to someone you trust, breaking big tasks into smaller steps.

> **Common Mistake**
> Relying only on avoidance (constant distraction, substance use) to cope with stress tends to make it worse over time rather than resolving it.

4. Anxiety Basics

Anxiety is a natural response to uncertainty or perceived threat. Occasional anxiety before a big event is normal; it becomes a concern when it is frequent, intense, or starts interfering with daily life.

- **May include:** Restlessness, racing thoughts, difficulty concentrating, physical symptoms like a racing heart.
- **Helpful approaches:** Slow breathing techniques, grounding exercises, reducing caffeine, talking to a professional if it persists.

5. Depression Awareness

Depression is more than ordinary sadness — it is a common, genuine health condition that can affect anyone, and it is treatable.

- **May include:** Persistent low mood, loss of interest in things once enjoyed, changes in sleep or appetite, low energy, lasting most of the day for two weeks or more.
- **What helps:** Talking to a trusted person, professional counselling or treatment, and avoiding isolation.

> **Support Is Available**
> If you or someone you know is struggling, Tele-MANAS — India's free, 24x7 government mental health helpline — is available on **14416** in over 20 languages. No referral is needed, and it is completely confidential.

6. Work-Life Balance

- Set clear boundaries around work hours where possible, including for remote or hybrid work.
- Protect time for rest, hobbies, and relationships outside of work.
- Recognise early signs of burnout: exhaustion, cynicism, and reduced sense of accomplishment.
- Take breaks during the workday rather than only at the end of it.

7. Digital Well-being

Constant notifications, social comparison, and "doomscrolling" can quietly affect mood and sleep.

- Set specific times to check messages and social media, rather than constantly.
- Turn off non-essential notifications.

- Keep phones out of the bedroom, especially near bedtime.
- Notice how specific apps make you feel, and adjust usage accordingly.

> **Tip**
> The Government of India's MANAS app offers guided meditation, mood tracking, and relaxation tools as a free starting point for digital well-being.

8. Sleep Hygiene

Habit	Why It Helps
Consistent sleep and wake times	Regulates your body's internal clock
No screens 30–60 minutes before bed	Reduces blue light disruption to sleep hormones
Cool, dark, quiet room	Supports deeper, uninterrupted sleep
Avoiding caffeine late in the day	Prevents delayed or disrupted sleep onset

9. Mindfulness & Relaxation

- **Deep breathing:** Slow, deep breaths activate the body's natural relaxation response.
- **Grounding:** Notice 5 things you can see, 4 you can hear, 3 you can touch, to anchor yourself in the present moment.
- **Mindful moments:** Even 5–10 minutes of quiet, focused attention daily can reduce stress over time.

10. Seeking Professional Help

Professional	What They Do
Counsellor	Talk-based support for everyday stress, relationship, or adjustment concerns
Clinical Psychologist	Structured therapy for anxiety, depression, and other conditions
Psychiatrist	A medical doctor who can diagnose and prescribe medication when needed

> **Where To Start**
> Call Tele-MANAS (14416) for a free, confidential first conversation — counsellors can guide you toward further in-person care through your local District Mental Health Programme (DMHP) centre if needed.

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
Mental Health	Emotional, psychological, and social well-being.
Stress	The body's natural response to pressure or demand.
Anxiety	Excessive worry or fear, sometimes with physical symptoms.
Depression	A persistent, treatable mood condition involving low mood and loss of interest.

Burnout	Exhaustion caused by prolonged, unmanaged work-related stress.
Mindfulness	Paying deliberate, non-judgemental attention to the present moment.
Treatment Gap	The difference between the number of people who need mental health care and those who receive it.
Stigma	Negative attitudes or shame associated with a condition, often preventing help-seeking.

Step-by-Step Understanding

Building a Personal Mental Well-being Routine

1. **Check in daily:** Take a moment to honestly notice how you're feeling.
2. **Protect the basics:** Prioritise sleep, movement, and regular meals.
3. **Stay connected:** Make time for people who support you.
4. **Practise a relaxation technique:** Even a few minutes of breathing or mindfulness daily helps.
5. **Set digital boundaries:** Reduce passive scrolling, especially before bed.
6. **Know your support options:** Save the Tele-MANAS number before you need it.
7. **Reach out early:** Talk to someone, professionally or personally, before things feel unmanageable.

Real-Life Indian Examples

Example 1

A software engineer in Bengaluru noticed persistent exhaustion and irritability after months of long work hours. Recognising the early signs of burnout, he began setting firm work-hour boundaries and resumed his weekend cycling routine — his mood and sleep improved within weeks.

Example 2

A college student in Delhi struggling with exam-related anxiety called Tele-MANAS out of curiosity one evening. The counsellor's calm, practical guidance helped her build a simple breathing routine she still uses before every exam.

Example 3

A homemaker in Nagpur, feeling persistently low for weeks after a personal loss, was gently encouraged by her daughter to speak to a counsellor at their local DMHP centre — she later described it as the first time she felt truly heard.

Example 4

A father in Chennai noticed his teenage son withdrawing from friends and constantly on his phone late at night. Instead of confronting him, he started with an open, judgement-free conversation — leading to an honest discussion about school stress.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario	What You Should Do

You've felt persistently low and unmotivated for over two weeks	Talk to someone you trust, and consider calling Tele-MANAS (14416) for guidance.
A colleague seems constantly exhausted and withdrawn	Check in with them gently, without judgement, and let them know support is available.
You feel anxious before every important event	Try a grounding or breathing technique, and consider professional support if it's frequent.
Your child seems to be spending most of their time alone on their phone	Start an open conversation rather than an accusation, focused on understanding, not blame.
You're unsure whether what you're feeling needs professional help	Call Tele-MANAS anyway — it's free, confidential, and doesn't require a formal diagnosis first.

Government Rules & Guidelines

Programme	Role
National Mental Health Programme (NMHP)	India's overarching policy framework for mental health care since 1982.
District Mental Health Programme (DMHP)	Delivers mental health services at the district level, closer to where people live.
Tele-MANAS (National Tele Mental Health Programme)	Free 24x7 helpline (14416) launched in 2022, now active across all States and UTs.
MANAS App	A free government wellness app for meditation, mood tracking, and relaxation tools.

Laws & Policies

The Mental Healthcare Act, 2017

This law recognises every person's right to access mental healthcare, protects the rights and dignity of persons with mental illness, decriminalises suicide attempts (treating them as a call for help and care, not a criminal offence), and aims to reduce stigma in how mental illness is treated legally and socially.

Important Statistics

Statistic	Insight
10.56% of Indian adults have a current mental disorder (National Mental Health Survey, NIMHANS)	Roughly 1 in 10 adults — a common, not rare, experience.
Overall treatment gap of 84.5% for mental disorders in India	Fewer than 1 in 6 people who need care are receiving it.
Over 32 lakh calls handled by Tele-MANAS since its 2022 launch	Shows rapidly growing awareness and willingness to seek help.
Suicide remains a significant public health concern in India (NCRB data)	A reminder that early, compassionate support saves lives — help is always available via Tele-MANAS (14416).

Suggested Visual: A simple "mental health spectrum" graphic moving from thriving to unwell, with supportive actions at each stage.

Best Practices

- Check in with your own mood and energy honestly, not just when things feel wrong.
- Build small, consistent habits — sleep, movement, connection — rather than relying on occasional big efforts.
- Talk about mental health openly with family, especially with children and teenagers.
- Treat professional help-seeking as a sign of strength, not weakness.
- Save the Tele-MANAS number in your phone today, before you might need it.

Common Mistakes

- Dismissing persistent low mood or anxiety as "just a phase."
- Waiting for things to become unbearable before seeking help.
- Assuming mental health struggles reflect personal weakness or failure.
- Comparing your inner struggles to someone else's outward appearance of "being fine."
- Avoiding conversations about mental health with children out of discomfort.

Mental Health Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"Mental health problems are a sign of personal weakness."	They are health conditions, influenced by biology, environment, and circumstance — not a character flaw.
"Talking about problems makes them worse."	Talking to a trusted person or professional is one of the most effective ways to feel better.
"Only 'serious' cases need professional help."	Support is valuable at every stage — you don't need to wait for a crisis to reach out.
"Children don't really experience stress or anxiety."	Children and teenagers experience real mental health struggles and benefit from open conversation and support.
"People with depression can just 'snap out of it.'"	Depression is a genuine health condition that usually needs support and sometimes treatment to improve.
"Seeking therapy means something is 'wrong' with you."	Therapy is a proactive wellness tool, used by many people simply to cope and grow better — not only in crisis.

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Talk openly about how you're feeling with someone you trust	Don't bottle up stress until it becomes overwhelming

Treat sleep, movement, and connection as non-negotiable basics	Don't sacrifice them entirely for work or study, even short-term
Reach out to Tele-MANAS if you're unsure where to start	Don't wait for a "serious enough" reason to ask for help
Approach a struggling friend or family member with empathy	Don't dismiss their feelings or compare their situation to others
Model healthy digital habits for children	Don't assume young people's stress is "not real"

Safety Tips

- If you ever feel unsafe with your own thoughts, reach out immediately — you don't have to manage it alone.
- Keep the Tele-MANAS number saved and easily accessible for yourself and people you care about.
- Encourage, but never force, a struggling loved one toward professional support.
- Remember that confidentiality is a core part of professional mental health support in India.

Support Is Available

Tele-MANAS: **14416** or **1-800-891-4416** — free, confidential, 24x7, in over 20 languages. No referral needed.

Practical Checklist

Personal Well-being Checklist

☐ Slept at least 7 hours last night
☐ Had at least one meaningful conversation today
☐ Took a break from screens at some point today
☐ Did something physically active today
☐ Practised a few minutes of mindfulness or deep breathing
☐ Know where to turn if I ever need extra support (Tele-MANAS: 14416)

Quick Revision Notes

Revision

- Mental health = emotional + psychological + social well-being, not just "absence of illness."
- It exists on a spectrum — thriving, coping, struggling, unwell — and shifts over time.
- Stress, anxiety, and low mood are common and manageable with the right tools and support.
- Tele-MANAS (14416) offers free, confidential, 24x7 support across India.
- The Mental Healthcare Act, 2017 protects your right to mental healthcare and decriminalises suicide attempts.
- Seeking help early is a sign of strength, not weakness.

Key Takeaways

Key Takeaway

1. Mental health is a normal, essential part of overall health — not a separate, lesser concern.
2. Most common struggles like stress, anxiety, and low mood are manageable and treatable.
3. India's biggest mental health challenge is the awareness and treatment gap, not a lack of available support.
4. Free, confidential help is available right now through Tele-MANAS (14416).
5. Small daily habits — sleep, connection, mindfulness — build long-term resilience.

Glossary

Mental Health — Emotional, psychological, and social well-being.

Stress — The body's natural response to pressure or demand.

Anxiety — Excessive worry or fear, sometimes with physical symptoms.

Depression — A persistent, treatable mood condition involving low mood and loss of interest.

Burnout — Exhaustion from prolonged, unmanaged stress, often work-related.

Mindfulness — Paying deliberate, non-judgemental attention to the present moment.

Treatment Gap — The difference between people needing mental health care and those receiving it.

DMHP — District Mental Health Programme, delivering local mental health services.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the WHO definition of mental health?

A state of well-being where a person can cope with life's normal stresses, work productively, and contribute to their community.

2. Is it normal to feel anxious sometimes?

Yes — occasional anxiety is a normal response to stress; it becomes a concern when persistent or disruptive.

3. What is the difference between sadness and depression?

Sadness usually passes with time; depression is more persistent, lasting most of the day for two weeks or more, and affects daily functioning.

4. Is Tele-MANAS free?

Yes — it is a completely free, confidential, government-run helpline.

5. Do I need a referral to call Tele-MANAS?

No — anyone can call directly, without a referral or formal diagnosis.

6. What languages is Tele-MANAS available in?

English and over 20 regional languages.

7. What is the difference between a psychologist and a psychiatrist?

A psychologist provides therapy and structured psychological support; a psychiatrist is a medical doctor who can also prescribe medication.

8. What is burnout?

Exhaustion caused by prolonged, unmanaged work-related stress, often with cynicism and reduced sense of accomplishment.

9. Can children experience anxiety or stress?

Yes — young people experience genuine mental health struggles and benefit from open, supportive conversation.

10. What does the Mental Healthcare Act, 2017 do?

It protects the right to mental healthcare, decriminalises suicide attempts, and reduces stigma in how mental illness is treated legally.

11. How can I improve my sleep hygiene?

Keep consistent sleep times, avoid screens before bed, and keep your room cool, dark, and quiet.

12. What is a simple way to manage sudden anxiety?

Try slow, deep breathing or a grounding technique, noticing things you can see, hear, and touch.

13. Is therapy only for people in crisis?

No — many people use therapy proactively for general well-being and personal growth, not only in a crisis.

14. What is the District Mental Health Programme (DMHP)?

A government programme delivering mental health services at the district level, closer to where people live.

15. How big is India's mental health treatment gap?

Around 84.5% overall, according to the National Mental Health Survey — meaning most people who need care aren't receiving it.

16. What is the MANAS app?

A free government wellness app offering guided meditation, mood tracking, and relaxation tools.

17. Should I be concerned if a friend seems withdrawn for weeks?

Yes — gently check in with them and encourage them to talk to someone or call Tele-MANAS.

18. Can stress actually be helpful?

In short bursts, yes — it can sharpen focus; it becomes harmful when prolonged or excessive.

19. What are healthy ways to manage work-life balance?

Set clear work-hour boundaries, take regular breaks, and protect time for rest and relationships.

20. Is it okay to talk to my family about mental health struggles?

Yes — open, honest conversation is one of the most protective things a family can offer each other.

21. What is mindfulness?

Paying deliberate, non-judgemental attention to the present moment, often through breathing or awareness exercises.

22. How quickly can Tele-MANAS connect me to a counsellor?

It is designed as an immediate, 24x7 service, connecting callers to a trained counsellor right away.

23. What if I don't know whether what I'm feeling is "serious enough"?

Call Tele-MANAS anyway — support is available at every stage, not only in a crisis.

24. Can digital habits affect mental health?

Yes — excessive scrolling, notifications, and social comparison can affect mood, focus, and sleep.

25. What is the single most important message of this handbook?

Mental health struggles are common and treatable, and free, confidential support is always available through Tele-MANAS (14416).

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Tables

Infographic: The Mental Health Spectrum, from thriving to unwell.

Illustration: A simple grounding technique (5-4-3-2-1) shown step by step.

Card: Tele-MANAS number and what to expect when calling, for quick reference.

Poster: Sleep hygiene habits, shown as a bedtime checklist.

Comparison Card: Counsellor vs Psychologist vs Psychiatrist, simply explained.

Official References

- National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences (NIMHANS), on behalf of the Ministry of Health & Family Welfare — National Mental Health Survey of India, 2015–16.
- Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India — Tele-MANAS (National Tele Mental Health Programme).
- The Mental Healthcare Act, 2017, Government of India.
- National Mental Health Programme (NMHP) and District Mental Health Programme (DMHP) guidelines.
- World Health Organization — definitions and guidance on mental health and well-being.
- National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) — Accidental Deaths & Suicides in India report.

Official Government Website Links

Resource	Website
Tele-MANAS	telemanas.mohfw.gov.in
Ministry of Health & Family Welfare	mohfw.gov.in
NIMHANS	nimhans.ac.in
National Health Portal of India	nhp.gov.in
National Health Mission	nhm.gov.in

Conclusion

Mental health is not a separate, optional part of well-being — it is health, full stop. Whether it's managing everyday stress, recognising the early signs of anxiety or depression, or simply building better sleep and digital habits, small, consistent steps genuinely help.

Most importantly, remember that support is never far away. Tele-MANAS is free, confidential, and just a phone call away at 14416 — for you, or for anyone you care about. As you move ahead in the JanGyan platform, use the Practice and Quiz sections to reinforce what you've learned here, and don't hesitate to use AI Assistance whenever a doubt arises.

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